

Annotated Bibliography

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MA Thesis Proposal · Uppsala University · 2026

“Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate”

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- 1.** Hugaas, K.H. (2024). Bleed and identity: A conceptual model of bleed and how bleed-out from role-playing games can affect a player’s sense of self. *International Journal of Role-Playing*, 15, 9–35. [THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK]
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This journal article develops the most comprehensive conceptual model of bleed available in role-playing game scholarship. The paper defines bleed as the bidirectional spillover of mental and physical states, values, opinions, and similar personal material between player and character, a term coined by Emily Care Boss (2007) and refined here into a full theoretical framework. A central contribution is the bleed perception threshold: Hugaas argues that bleed occurs in all players, but whether the player notices it depends on whether it crosses their individual threshold, a distinction that decouples bleed’s transformative effects from the player’s conscious awareness of them. The paper distinguishes bleed-in (player to character) from bleed-out (character to player) and focuses particularly on bleed-out’s effects on the player’s sense of self. It synthesizes and extends earlier work into a taxonomy of types including emotional, procedural, memetic, ego, identity, emancipatory, and romantic bleed; identity bleed, where deeper self-schemas shift through character inhabitation, is one of Hugaas’s original contributions.

Bleed is the mechanism through which debate’s documented transformative effects are produced and explained in my thesis. The three types deployed most directly are memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and argumentative perspectives into the debater’s worldview outside the round; procedural bleed, the transfer of rhetorical habits and communication skills into ordinary life; and emancipatory bleed, where students from marginalized backgrounds develop intellectual voice through the identity work of being taken seriously as arguers. The bleed perception threshold concept is useful for the thesis’s empirical grounding: it explains why debaters often cannot articulate how debate changed them even as longitudinal studies document consistent attitudinal shifts. For how debate is broken, existing formats produce bleed without designing for it, leaving its direction and content to competitive pressures rather than transformative goals. For why the Inside Out format should work, its design addresses bleed at the

level of each type: the character assignment shapes memetic bleed, the debrief converts bleed-out into conscious integration, and explicit identity-distance mechanisms protect emancipatory bleed from being overridden by competitive anxiety.

2. Daniau, S. (2016). The transformative potential of role-playing games: From play skills to human skills. *Simulation & Gaming*, 47(4), 423–444. [THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK]

Drawing on a doctoral dissertation and ongoing action research, this peer-reviewed SAGE journal article develops the concept of the Transformative Role-Playing Game (TF-RPG): a tabletop RPG combined with a formal structured debrief session facilitated after play. Daniau’s core theoretical contribution is that participants in RPGs simultaneously occupy four levels of reality (character, player, person, and human being) and that the transfer of in-game skills to lasting human competencies does not happen automatically through play alone. It requires structured reflective processing during which participants consciously map game experiences onto their own personal journeys. He builds a four-dimensional learning framework (knowing, doing, being, and relating) and argues that TF-RPGs uniquely engage all four, making them far more educationally powerful than conventional instruction. Without the debrief, play skills remain sealed inside the game. Daniau’s four levels map the psychological terrain of what happens inside the transformational container described by Bowman et al. (2025): the container sets the conditions, but Daniau’s debrief is the mechanism that converts bleed-out into lasting change. His framework also resonates with Kolb’s (1984) experiential learning cycle, in which reflective observation and abstract conceptualization (the stages where raw experience becomes generalized learning) can only be activated by structured processing.

For my claim that debate is a role-playing game, Daniau’s taxonomy of role-playing types, which includes educational role-playing and simulation alongside more traditional RPG formats, positions debate naturally within a continuum of transformative role-playing activities. For how debate is broken, Daniau’s insight that the debrief is what converts play skills into human skills becomes a pointed critique of current debate formats: the oral critique processes argumentative performance (the character and player levels) but entirely neglects the person and human being levels: there is no emotional processing, no de-roling, and no structured connection between in-round experience and the debater’s developing self-concept. For why the Inside Out format should work, I design an explicit debrief structure informed by Daniau that addresses all four levels: it processes what arguments were made (character), how the debater performed (player), what it felt like to argue from that position (person), and what it

means for how the debater understands disagreement and persuasion in life (human being).

3. Bowman, S.L. (2010). *The functions of role-playing games: How participants create community, solve problems, and explore identity*. McFarland. [THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK]

This scholarly ethnography, based on participant-observer research and extensive qualitative interviews with nineteen role-players across tabletop, LARP, and virtual formats, identifies three core functions of role-playing: communal cohesion (role-playing creates group identity through shared narrative ritual), scenario-based problem solving (role-playing develops cognitive, interpersonal, cultural, and professional skills through structured enactment of complex situations), and identity alteration (role-playing provides a safe space to enact alternate personas). The book's most theoretically generative contribution for my purposes is Chapter 7's taxonomy of nine types of character-player relationships, among them the Fragmented Self, the Oppositional Self, the Experimental Self, and the Repressed Self, each describing a different way that a player's own psychological content is activated, magnified, or reorganized through the character. Central to all nine types is the concept of adopting a theory of mind: thinking as if one were someone else in a unique set of circumstances, which Bowman argues develops empathy and expands participants' understanding of perspectives beyond their own. This framework provides the foundational identity architecture that underpins the bleed taxonomy in Bowman et al. (2025): bleed can only flow between player and character because the character is built from the player's own psychological material: fragments, repressions, ideals, experiments. Without the nine-type identity structure, bleed would be a metaphor without a mechanism.

For my claim that debate is a role-playing game, Bowman's framework is decisive: the debater's relationship to their assigned position is structurally identical to what she calls the Fragmented Self relationship. The debater does not pretend to believe the motion; they locate within themselves the fragments of belief, knowledge, and rhetorical disposition that can genuinely support it, then magnify those fragments into a complete epistemic stance. This is authentic identity work, not theatrical performance, and this is why debate produces real cognitive and attitudinal effects rather than merely simulated ones. For how debate is broken, the communal cohesion function reveals a double-edged dynamic: the tight sub-culture of competitive debate creates strong in-group identity, but when that identity becomes hierarchically structured around tournament success, the community begins to suppress rather than expand its members' identities, blocking the Experimental Self and Repressed Self relationships that would produce the most

growth. For why the Inside Out format should work, I design character assignments that deliberately activate the Oppositional Self relationship: debaters are given not just a side but a specific persona whose perspective differs meaningfully from their own, and structured community practices strengthen the communal cohesion function without generating competitive hierarchy.

4. Hammer, J., To, A., Schrier, K., Bowman, S.L., & Kaufman, G. (2024). Learning and role-playing games. In J.P. Zagal & S. Deterding (Eds.), *The Routledge Handbook of Role-Playing Game Studies* (pp. 299–317). Routledge. [THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK]

This book chapter provides a comprehensive synthesis of educational theory as applied to role-playing games. The authors situate RPGs within four learning theory traditions (behaviorism, cognitivism, constructivism, and sociocultural theory) and argue that RPGs operate primarily through constructionist and sociocultural mechanisms: they are shared constructions of fictional reality requiring players to adopt and inhabit new roles within a community of practice. The chapter's central contribution is a taxonomy of five educational features distinctive to RPGs: character portrayal (enabling perspective-taking, experience-taking, and vicarious experience); manipulation of a fictional world through theorycrafting and authentic simulation; experiencing an altered sense of reality, which can either heighten the emotional stakes of fictional decisions or lower the stakes of realistic ones; supporting collaboration through shared imaginative spaces; and learning through making RPGs, including modding, designing new games, and using game creation as critical making practice. Research synthesized in the chapter shows that perspective-taking through character adoption increases empathy and reduces reliance on stereotypes, while experience-taking (deeper immersion where players simulate a character's subjective experience) produces temporary internalization of the character's personality traits and behavior. The chapter also identifies the debrief as the mechanism through which in-game experiences are processed for learning, distinguishing emotional, intellectual, and educational processing, and emphasizing that without structured reflection, learning remains locked inside the game experience.

This chapter is the educational theory bridge between RPG scholarship and the thesis's claims about debate. The five educational features of RPGs map onto the debate encounter: switch-side argumentation is a form of character portrayal that cultivates perspective-taking comparable to role adoption in RPGs; the adversarial dialogue is a form of authentic simulation where debaters experiment with how argumentative positions hold up under pressure; team preparation is a form of collaborative shared imagination. Hammer et al.'s evidence that immersion depth correlates with internalization of character-perspective traits provides theoretical warrant for designing debate

formats that deepen character identification rather than treating position assignment as a strategic convenience. Their debrief taxonomy clarifies why the oral critique falls short: because educational processing requires structured reflection connecting in-game experience to real-world understanding, a critique focused exclusively on argumentative performance does not activate the learning mechanisms the debate format has already engaged.

5. Deterding, S. (2017). Alibis for adult play: A Goffmanian account of escaping embarrassment in adult play. *Games and Culture*, 13(3), 260–279. [THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK]

This journal article develops the concept of alibi from Erving Goffman’s sociology of face-work and frame analysis. In Goffman’s account, face is the positive social value a person claims for themselves in interaction; adult life is governed by norms of seriousness that make play a potential threat to face, liable to make the player appear childish or frivolous. Deterding argues that adult play persists because participants deploy alibis: motivational accounts that deflect negative inference from displayed behavior to a person’s identity. The paper identifies two sources of alibi. First, motivational accounting systems, in which players reframe play through adult-appropriate purposes such as professional development, family engagement, or health: play becomes legitimate because it serves a serious end. Second, keyings or reframings, in which play is bracketed as non-serious through ironic, humorous, or self-distancing performance that signals the player’s distance from the activity (deliberately bad karaoke, for instance, preemptively frames mediocre performance as intentional). Together these mechanisms create plausible deniability: the reason for engaging in the behavior is not “I want to play” but “I have good adult reasons for this activity” or “I am not really doing this seriously.”

In the thesis, alibi is the concept that explains why debate’s epistemic character inhabitation is psychologically safe: debaters can argue for positions contrary to their own beliefs because the competitive frame provides alibi. The random side assignment is the mechanism: the reason a debater argues for a position is “I was assigned this side,” not “I personally believe this,” which deflects inference from displayed behavior to the game’s structure. This is what Seo (2022) describes as debate providing a “sense of freedom” to “flirt with ideas, unencumbered by expectations of consistency or deep conviction.” For how debate is broken, when competitive pressures make tournament success feel like a measure of personal worth, the alibi erodes: participants can no longer treat debate as just a game because the stakes have become real, and the protected space for identity risk-taking collapses. For why the Inside Out format should work,

it calibrates alibi deliberately: enough protective bracketing for participants to take genuine identity risks, but with debrief practices that thin the alibi at specific points so bleed-out can enter conscious reflection rather than dissipate.
